



Sunflowers Around Lake Providence — The Short Version

For anybody thinking about growing or handling sunflowers in the Delta • July 2026

The bottom line: Sunflowers **will grow here just fine**. The problem is **nobody around here buys them**. The closest buyer is about **600 miles away in Lubbock, Texas** (a birdseed company called Red River Commodities). The big oil plants are way up in North Dakota. So the question isn't "can we grow them" — it's "**who's gonna buy them and what does the truck ride cost.**"

The money, simple

- Buyers were paying about **\$22–23 per hundred pounds** for oil sunflowers (late-2025 prices — check current prices before planting).
- Trucking a load to Lubbock costs roughly **\$1,800 a truck**, which eats about **\$3.50–\$4.00** of that \$22. You keep the rest, minus drying and handling.
- **Thin money, but real money.** Prices jump around a lot — they nearly doubled in the 2021 drought.

Three ways to get in (easiest first)

1. **Grow it and ship it.** Get a contract with a buyer **FIRST**, grow the crop, dry it, put it on a truck. Cheapest way to start — you mostly just need to dry the seed right. This proves the crop works here.
2. **Team up with a local elevator.** A regular grain elevator can handle sunflowers — no fancy equipment needed. Two rules: dry the seed down to about **10% moisture**, and **clean the dryer every day** (sunflower fuzz catches fire in dryers — dirty equipment is what burns, not hot air). Don't do this until a buyer signs a contract.
3. **Bag your own birdseed and deer-plot seed.** Clean it, screen it, bag it, sell it to feed stores and hunters right here. No 600-mile truck ride, and this is deer country. Setup might run **\$150,000–\$500,000**, but honestly **nobody knows yet** — internet prices turned out to be junk. Get real quotes first.

Best order: 1, then 2, then 3. Prove it, pile it up, then process it.

Free money worth chasing

- **USDA grant (VAPG)** pays up to about **\$75,000** just to have a real feasibility study done — the smart first move.
- **Louisiana ag department (LDAF)** handed out \$4.6 million in food-processing grants in 2024. Watch for the next round.

Do this next

1. **Call Red River Commodities** (Lubbock): will you buy Louisiana sunflowers, at what price, delivered?
2. **Get a real trucking quote**, Lake Providence to Lubbock.
3. **Get written equipment quotes** — don't trust internet prices.
4. **Check current prices** at sunflowernsa.com before deciding anything.

⚠ Every dollar figure here is from late 2025 and prices move. Don't plant a seed until you have a signed contract from a buyer.